shock from the apartment door. The fate that had befallen so many others was now also Landau's.

The limousine took Landau to one of Moscow's most notorious political prisons, the Butyrskaya. There he was told that his activities as a German spy had been discovered, and he was to pay the price for them. That the charges were ludicrous (Landau, a Jew and an ardent Marxist spying for Nazi Germany?) was irrelevant. The charges almost always were ludicrous. In Stalin's Russia one rarely knew the real reason one had been imprisoned-though in Landau's case, there are indications in recently revealed KGB files: In conversations with colleagues, he had criticized the Communist party and the Soviet government for their manner of organizing scientific research, and for the massive arrests of 1936–37 that ushered in the Great Terror. Such criticism was regarded as an "anti-Soviet activity" and could easily land one in prison.

Landau was lucky. His imprisonment lasted but one year, and he survived it—just barely. He was released in April 1939 after Pyotr Kapitsa, the most famous Soviet experimental physicist of the 1930s, appealed directly to Molotov and Stalin to let him go on grounds that Landau and only Landau, of all Soviet theoretical physicists, had the ability to solve the mystery of how superfluidity comes about.[6] (Superfluidity had been discovered in Kapitsa's laboratory, and independently by J. F. Allen and A. D. Misener in Cambridge, England, and if it could be explained by a Soviet scientist, this would demonstrate doubly to the world the power of Soviet science.)

Landau emerged from prison emaciated and extremely ill. In due course, he recovered physically and mentally, solved the mystery of superfluidity using the laws of quantum mechanics, and received the Nobel Prize for his solution. But his spirit was broken. Never again could he withstand even mild psychological pressure from the political authorities.

Oppenheimer

In California, Robert Oppenheimer was in the habit of reading with care every scientific article published by Landau. Thus, Landau's article on neutron cores in the 19 February 1938 issue of *Nature* caught his immediate attention. Coming from Fritz Zwicky, the idea of a neutron star as the